

Build an Excel Dashboard in Under 1 Hour

Step by step. No VBA. No prior experience required.

Riley Stream

BEFORE YOU BUILD ANYTHING

Every good dashboard starts with one question: What decision does this help someone make? If you can't answer that in one sentence, you're not ready to build yet. Write the question first. The dashboard is just the answer.

STEP 1 - Structure Your Raw Data as a Table

Click anywhere in your data. Press Ctrl+T. Name it something readable like SalesData or OrderLog. Every formula you write now auto-expands when new data comes in.

STEP 2 - Separate Sheets for Data, Pivots, Dashboard

Never build dashboard + pivots on the same sheet. Create three sheets: DATA / PIVOTS / DASHBOARD. When something breaks (and it will), you know where to look.

STEP 3 - Decide Your KPIs Before You Touch Design

Pick your 3-5 KPIs. Total revenue. Units sold. Top category. Whatever the dashboard is for. Build those pivot tables FIRST. Design SECOND. Most people do this backwards.

STEP 4 - Add Slicers for One-Click Filtering

Click your pivot -> Insert -> Slicer. Choose your filter fields. Now your dashboard filters with one click. No dropdowns. No formulas. The single feature that makes non-Excel people feel like they can use your file.

STEP 5 - Charts: Bar for Comparison, Line for Trends. That's It.

No 3D charts. No pie charts with 12 slices. No donuts. Bar for categorical comparison. Line for time series. Two chart types handle 95% of dashboards. Resist everything else.

STEP 6 - Layout: One Metric Per Section. White Space Is Not Wasted Space.

Don't cram. Group related metrics. Use Excel's gridlines off (View -> uncheck Gridlines). Add a title at the top. Looks finished, takes 90 seconds.

STEP 7 - Lock the Dashboard Sheet

Review -> Protect Sheet. Users can refresh and click slicers; they can't accidentally break formulas. The dashboard you ship in 60 minutes survives the next 60 weeks.

3 THINGS THAT KILL DASHBOARDS

1. Too many metrics - if everything is important, nothing is.
2. No data validation - garbage in, garbage out.
3. Building for yourself, not the person who'll use it.

What's the first dashboard you're building with this?

Drop it in the comments. Save this for the next time someone asks. And follow for more step-by-step Excel content.

*Want structured learning to go deeper? I recommend Maven Analytics' Excel + Power BI tracks.
Affiliate link available in my Substack.*

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